FROM THE EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

They are not born artists or entertainers. They did not go to film school. Or learn fancy video editing and scriptwriting at an elite institute. They turned to the dross material of their own daily humdrum lives, and alchemised that into pure gold. Take Usha Bishayee, 51, who shares traditional Bengali recipes. One reel won her 430,000 hearts and 4.7 million views. It was simplicity itself, but encapsulated the meteoric rise to fame of her breed. She was describing her first trip outside of West Bengal; the first flight that took her to Mumbai, where she'd eventually meet, and dance alongside, Instagram head Adam Mosseri. You have the likes of podcaster Raj Shamani, whose 10 million YouTube subscriber base persuaded Bill Gates to sit down for an interview with him. And also to have tea made by the flashy Dolly Chai Wala of Nagpur (5 million Insta followers). There are those with a mission. Santosh Jadhav and co-founder Akash Jadhav created @indianfarmer in 2018 to make YouTube videos on sustainable agriculture. This side hustle turned out to be much more 'sustainable'. They now have 4.94 million subscribers, an annual turnover of Rs 1.5 crore through ad revenue and brand deals, and a production team. That's why Ajay Vidyasagar, MD, YouTube South East Asia, calls all this "extraordinarily inspiring". YouTube alone paid out Rs 21,000 crore in 2022-24 to those who create content in India: the sector now includes not just traditional media giants but also a burgeoning band of solo creators and artists. It plans to invest Rs 850 crore in the coming two years to accelerate growth.

We are calling it the New Creator Economy. At its heart is digital content. Such torrents of it that it's become the common Indian's gold rush. The world's most populous nation makes each number related to this new economy a jaw-dropping one. India has 4.6 million digital content creators, and counting. They make the most number of Instagram reels in the world. About 6 million a day! It also has the most YouTube channels—over 100 million of them. More than 15,000 of these have a subscriber base exceeding a million. It helps that Indians are second only to Brazilians and Indonesians in spending time online. They log a daily average of five hours, of which 70 per cent is spent on social media, video platforms and gaming. In 2024, that made for a total of 1.1 trillion hours, according to EY. No wonder digital channels eclipsed television to emerge as the biggest segment of the Rs 2.5 lakh crore media and entertainment (M&E) industry. Their total valuation, Rs 80,200 crore in 2024, is expected to touch Rs 90,300 crore

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this year. Within that, the value of the rising Indian influencer marketing industry alone is Rs 3,600 crore and it's expected to grow at 25 per cent in the coming year. Calling it a sunrise sector would be a misnomer. It's like a billion sunrises dawning every second on a billion smartphone screens.

Behind this boom, there are no moguls or magnates. No master plan from a management whiz. Instead, you have a motley crew of unlikely self-born megastars who have crashed the party of the old, established M&E behemoths. They are in fact the new mainstream. What else do you call a regular, moustachioed Malayali mister like KL Bro Biju, who puts up simple family videos and gathers an unearthly subscriber base of 72.7 million! And all of it organic. Some of them churn out 'timepass' videos that are even intended to be 'so bad that they're good'. Like Rajkumar Thakuria, aka Raku Da, a 70-year-old retired banker from Assam, whose 'cringe pop' has earned him 236,000 followers on Instagram.

No wonder that, at the recent World Audio Visual & Entertainment Summit (WAVES) in Mumbai, creators and digital platforms were as much the centre of attraction as Bollywood celebrities. All of it flows from the sheer, unaffected joy with which these new-age products are made, distributed and consumed. Likes, heart signs, thumbs-ups and shares are their currency, not glitzy advertisements. Make no mistake. What we are witnessing is a phase of transition. All traditional M&E platforms are a touch out of breath and behind the curve. Films are struggling. Print and TV lean on the digital 'platform economy' to ply their wares. On the other hand, a complete newcomer can attain virality because the means of production have been democratised. Today's smartphones come with reliably advanced features even at price ranges within reach for most. And the WiFi revolution since Jio was launched in 2016 has spawned entire digital communities who have grown up on YouTube and Instagram. The Covid-19 pandemic only deepened everyone's immersion. So this is how the 21st century is panning out. Not on a 70 mm silver screen, but on a miniaturised canvas that everyone carries around with them.

Deputy Editor Suhani Singh takes a break from her regular cinema and entertainment industry beat to look at how Indians are fundamentally shifting to this new mode of producing and consuming content. With her twin focal lengths, she spots and appreciates the contrasts straight off. "There are no entry barriers, no cliques or dynastic cabals to navigate as in Bollywood, no degree or special knowledge required. All you need is an authentic self," she says. Our cover story this week tips its hat at this new digital exchange for dreams and desires.

(Aroon Purie)